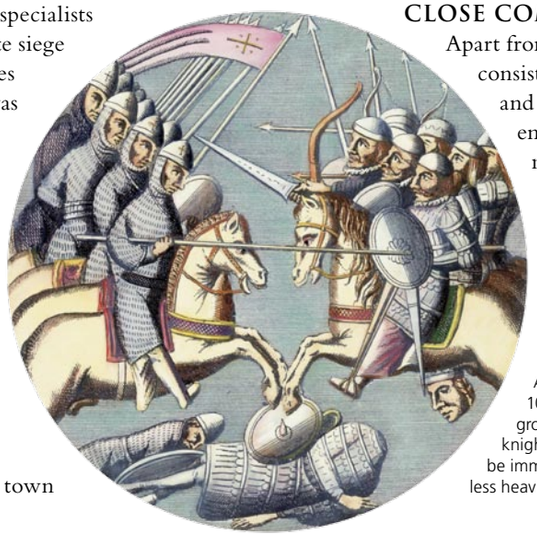
Siege warfare
An illustration from the *Chronicles of Charles VII* showing a group of knights and other men-at-arms under the banner of the Dauphin Louis spearheading an assault on the bastille at Dieppe in 1443.

As professional soldiers, knights often conducted campaigns in which such noble passages at arms were rare. Pitched battles were uncommon in medieval warfare. Instead, siege warfare occupied centre stage. Since the building of castles and fortified towns was highly developed, sieges were as prolonged as they were frequent. Knights occasionally performed heroics in assaulting castle walls, but more often their role was marginal, since specialists were employed to operate siege engines or to to dig mines under defences. There was little but boredom and hardship to be found in camping for months in unhealthy conditions outside the walls of a town, or in being one of the besieged defenders, and it was not unknown for knights from the opposing sides to agree to stage a tournament to alleviate the tedium. If a town held out until it was taken by storm, the rules of war permitted the victors to relieve their frustrations by subjecting its population to pillage and slaughter. This was a right of which knights took full advantage, as when crusaders massacred the citizens of Jerusalem in 1099 or when the Black Prince ordered the systematic slaughter of the people of Limoges in 1370.

CLOSE COMBAT

Apart from sieges, warfare consisted largely of raiding and laying waste to enemy territory, a messy business that imposed maximum cost upon local populations with



Knights of Christ
A line of crusader knights charge their opponents at Ascalon, near Jerusalem, in 1099. The impact from a group of well-ordered mounted knights moving at speed could be immense, particularly against less heavily armoured opposition.

PITCHED BATTLE TACTICS

The mounted element of a medieval army would consist of groups of 30 or 40 men-at-arms, each behind their leader's banner. A number of such groups, combined with foot soldiers, would form a "battle", the basic all-arms division. Two or three battles typically made up an army in the field. Drawing up his forces on the battlefield, an experienced commander would try to position them so they had the sun and wind at their backs. The more confident side would hope to win the battle through the shock effect of a charge by its mounted knights and other men-at-arms.

CHARGE AND COUNTER-CHARGE

A commander who intended to stand on the defensive would exploit natural obstacles such as hedges, ditches, or soft ground to block the enemy charge. Alternatively, his soldiers would create artificial obstacles, digging trenches or making palisades. After some preliminary skirmishing, especially by bowmen, the knights on one side would launch their charge, surging forward on horseback or on foot to engage their opposite numbers with lance, mace, axe, and sword. If the initial advance was halted, the men-at-arms standing on the defensive would advance on foot to engage the opposing knights in a mêlée or might mount to deliver a counter-charge.